cool ventures
empowering local businesses

SGBSS Verification of Support Provided and Action Plan

Contact Name		Grace Omotuase	
Intervention Type	Video Conf	Date of Session	26/3/26

NOTES FROM MEETING (Objective, business aspirations / challenges, overview of discussion)	Duration of support (hrs)
Background You are sole director of Green Africa Hub Ltd registered 21st March 2026 You live in Bradley Stoke, you explained you want help to move from incorporation to operation. The goal of the business is to help African and Caribbean food business lower energy costs and reduce carbon by using electrical induction though a smart Kitchen Hub model. 90% of small producers use gas to cook, your goals are to: • Reduce gas use • Reduce packaging waste and reduce food miles • Increase use of renewable resources This was to be funded through a mix of funding, a membership model, workshop delivery and commission on equipment sales. You are additionally developing a sustainable cookbook. You presented a letter over screenshare, addressed to Cool Ventures and introducing yourself and explaining what you hoped to gain from the support; this letter has not as yet been sent to Cool Ventures. I took a screenshot of the section that explained what you wanted help with:	1

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The Support I Am Seeking from Cool Ventures

I am requesting support across six areas to launch the 6-month pilot programme:

- **Funding:** Referral to the WECA Green Business Grant (up to £15,000) for commercial induction equipment and kitchen fit-out.
- **Business Advice:** Business Scale-up Programme — up to 12 hours of free 1:1 expert support covering planning, finance, and growth strategy.
- **Carbon Support:** Registration for the BaNES Carbon Reduction Accelerator and referral WECA Low Carbon Business Support Team.
- **Space:** Introduction to shared commercial kitchen facilities in South Gloucestershire or Bristol.
- **Marketing:** Workshop support and introductions to African & Caribbean community networks across the West of England.
- **Endorsement:** B Corp Bootcamp enrolment and letters of support for grant applications

I explained that the referral to me was limited to an hours support, so whilst I would do my best to help and was prepared to be generous with my time also, I realistically would not be able to do all the things requested in the letter, and that I would need to signpost on some topics as opposed to refer.

Referral to Green Business Grant: Not possible, as this program has now closed: https://www.westofengland-ca.gov.uk/growth-hub/green-business-support/green-business-grants/
We discussed that you could consider a startup loan application as an alternative: https://www.startuploans.co.uk/ However later in our conversation, it transpired your visa runs out in December and I think until you have a longer visa, it will preclude loan application as whilst startup loans will loan to people on visas, they require repayment before the visa ends.

Access to Cool Ventures Business Scale Up Program: This is now called the Thrive program, it is aimed at businesses that are already trading and the minimum turnover requirement would normally be 30k. I will mention to the team that you have requested this, however this program would not normally be offered to a business that isn't trading yet: https://coolventures.co.uk/sglos-thrive-programme/
As the 121 support on our startup program is limited, you may wish to check out whether Black Southwest Network can offer you any additional business support: https://www.blacksouthwestnetwork.org/

Carbon Support – we looked at the surveys WECA can fund, these seem to be aimed at businesses with existing premises as they request the last 12 months electric bill and offer site visits. Given your business is yet to start trading and doesn't have a premises yet, I am not sure the low carbon surveys are useful for your business at this stage. The B&NES Carbon Reduction Accelerator is exclusively for businesses in B&NES and so you would not be eligible due to being out of area.

Space: We did an active referral to Producewest (https://producewest.co.uk/) for their kitchen space finder pilot, as well as put an enquiry in re shared kitchen space on the property search portal at Investin Bristol (https://www.bristolandbath.co.uk/). You are ideally looking for a shared community kitchen. Many of these seem to be advertised and examples we found included:
https://www.coexistcommunitykitchen.org/hire-our-space
https://cookingit.co.uk/commercial-kitchen-hire-bristol/
https://www.themaziproject.com/hire-the-mazi-community-kitchen-venue/
https://www.bristolcourses.com/venue-hire/stoke-lodge-kitchen/
You would need to do your research to see if any of these were suitable.

Marketing and Introductions
I have signposted to BSWN, who would be a good starting point for making connections. If you would like marketing training, here is the booking link to our next marketing course https://www.eventbrite.co.uk/e/effective-marketing-strategy-masterclass-tickets-1985070704915

In terms of connecting with local food businesses, potentially useful contacts will include the Bristol Food Network and Foodworks:
https://www.foodworks-sw.co.uk/
https://www.bristolfoodnetwork.org

B Corp Bootcamp Enrolment
We discussed B Corp application is quite a lot of work and it would not typically be something a prestart business would do at the outset. I will mention you have expressed an interest in the Bootcamp to the Cool Ventures Team.

Letters of support for grant applications
You explained you would like a letter of support from Cool Ventures endorsing your business. I explained I was technically external, so couldn't issue you with a letter of recommendation today. I explained you could however get an attendance certificate for our startup course; you explained you had done Part 1 and 2 of Startup Essentials so I will ask for the certificate for you.

Funding the workshops
You would like to apply for funding so can deliver workshops free of charge to participants. This could be challenging due to the structure, as you have a Ltd by shares company, and this will not be eligible for certain funding sources. We looked at the eligibility criteria for Quartet (a local funder) as an example; they expressly exclude application from companies limited by shares. You asked if it is possible to convert your Ltd to a CIC; it is, but it is not possible to directly convert a company limited by shares to one limited by guarantee so if you wanted a CIC Ltd by guarantee this would mean setting up a new company.
A way around the company structure issue, would be to partner with / subcontract from community partners who do have suitable status to apply for the community funding you want e.g. if you partner with a community kitchen that is a CIC, they may be able to bid for funding for your workshops in collaboration with you in their name, if the funding comes off

they keep back money for admin and kitchen hire, then subcontract to your Ltd for the workshop delivery. Funding options for more charitable structures can be found here: https://www.myfundingcentral.co.uk/
You may also wish to check out whether any grants listed at CSE could be suitable for you: https://www.cse.org.uk/my-community/funding-for-community-energy-projects/#grants

The other possible route, if your participants would not pay, would be to explore whether the manufacturers of the equipment you want to showcase, would lend you the equipment and then put you on commission if participants buy it and/or bring kit to showcase on the day.

Founder visa

You asked me about innovator visas and whether endorsement could be granted if yous started a CIC. I am not an immigration adviser and have no experience with this scheme, so it would be best to ask this question of your target endorsing body (Envestors) as they ultimately make the decision on which businesses to endorse; from what I can see online, it will be key to have a business plan showing the business is demonstrably viable/scalable.

ACTION PLAN (agreed with client)

Action	By Who	By When
Review notes above and make own plan	GO	Soon

REFERRALS & SIGN POSTING –

Type	Referred / Signposted to	Purpose of referral / signpost	Date made
Referral	Produce West / Investin Bristol	Find kitchen space	26/3/26
Signpost	Various	Various – see above	26/3/26

FOLLOW UP

Reason for follow up	Who	When
Standard Keep in touch activity	CV	ongoing